

The feud between the Karunanidhis and the Marans is now in the open and Maran has merely been made a scapegoat in the process. With A. Raja taking over as the new telecom minister, it is to be seen how he does justice to the job.

P.V. LAKSHMINARAYANAN,  
Chennai

## Mature Maya

Mayawati's thumping electoral victory in Uttar Pradesh elections is indicative of her political maturity ("Hot Pursuit", May 28). Although she adopted the strategy of pleasing Brahmins in the state, she triumphed without alienating the Muslim voters. This reflects her secular credential and credibility.

K.V. RAGHURAM, on e-mail

Mayawati is basking in her recent success. The real test, however, lies ahead, the result of which will be reflected in the way she rules Uttar Pradesh in the next five years.

VIRENDRA KUMAR TANGRI,  
Dehradun

## A Young Prez

Why can't India have a younger President ("Consensus vs Confusion", May 28)? Do any of the names that are being floated as the probable next President deserve the chair? The only common qualification they all have is that they are grand old men. The chair has become an instrument to accommodate useless politicians who are expected to kow-tow to the top party bosses.

LAXMAN PAWAR, Delhi

It is time to amend the Constitution of India. There should be a test to select the President of India. It's a dignified post and political parties should not be allowed to hijack it with secret agendas.

HRIDAY CHOUDHURY,  
Pathshala, Assam

## Scheme of Things

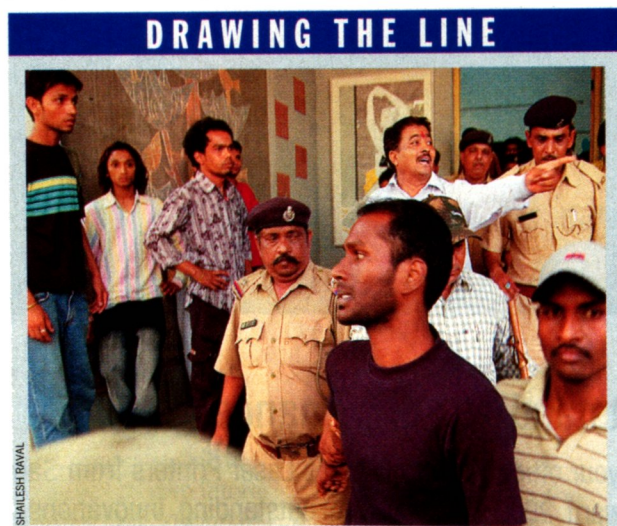
The Andhra Pradesh Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme is a model of effectiveness and probity. ("Transparent. gov.in", May 28). This example shows that the problem does not lie with policy but with implemen-

tation where most schemes in India falter.  
RAMANUJ KALITA, Tihu, Assam

## Selectively Secular

Anjolie Ela Menon seems to be secular when it comes to finding flaws with orthodox Hindus alone ("Why this Victorian Prudery", May 28). What happens when Danish cartoonist portrays Prophet Mohammad in a cartoon over which there is an uproar in the Muslim world? For the secular lot, it is fashionable to support Muslims instead of Hindus.

ASOKE C. BANERJEE,  
Kolkata



Chandra Mohan's paintings are repulsive and hurt religious sentiments ("The Art of War", May 28). Perversion in the name of artistic freedom can't be tolerated. The matter should be ignored as it is merely a publicity stunt.

SHARAD KETKAR, Mumbai

Art is associated with freedom of expression. There is nothing wrong with Mohan's paintings as he followed the muse within. He should not submit to the diktat of the self-appointed moral police.

ANIRBAN DASGUPTA, Mumbai

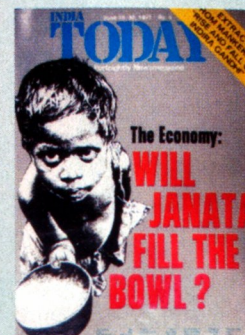
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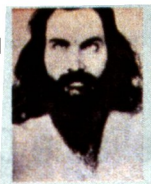
JUNE 16-30, 1977



## Sinning With Swami

By 1977, Swami Dharendra Brahmachari had become Rasputin and Tsar rolled into one. In a period of 15 years he had become the confidante of the Nehru family. He was a regular visitor to Mrs Gandhi's residence. Ministers and mendicants, businessmen and bureaucrats, smugglers and sycophants all ringed him.

Whether it was licence or libido, contracts or cabinet changes everything seemed to be solved by a single 'blessing' from the yogi. After the 1971 election the swami told his confidantes that he knew the exact composition of the cabinet. When he proved 100 per cent accurate, people with power and money took the hint. Simultaneously his visits to 1, Safdarjung Road continued. In fact Sanjay and Sonia were regular visitors to his ashram, Sonia spending on an average an hour to an hour-and-a-half every day.



The Swami

—Chand Joshi and  
Suchitra Behal

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